Gambling 3NT

Print Page Download PDF

1.9k Shares

Email Share Post

The Gambling 3NT is an opening 3NT bid showing a solid 7-8 card minor suit. (Possibly only 6 depending on agreement.) It typically denies a void or 4+ card side suit. Side suit strength depends on partnership style. Opener may have anywhere from 0-3 outside suits stopped. Let us call these the aggressive, moderate and conservative approaches.

Aggressive	Moderate	Conservative
♠84	♠Q32	♠A
♥42	♥A8	♥K43
♦73	♦9	♦KT
♣AKJT763	♣AKQ9752	♣AKJT872

Now, the earliest reference that I've found for the Gambling 3NT is "Howard Schenken's 'Big Club'" circa 1968. The late great Schenken defined his 3NT opening as a "solid minor suit, 17-21 HCP, 8.5-9 playing tricks, [and] should include [an] ace, king or queen in every suit."

This conservative approach has lost popularity, though, because it is less preemptive than the other two styles. The aggressive hand type is also more frequent than a running minor suit with ALL side suits stopped, which appears about as often as Halley's Comet.

That said, the disadvantage of an aggressive treatment is that it may wrong-side the contract when partner holds stoppers (read: tenaces) in the other three suits.

Why play the Gambling 3NT? The following tournament deal is an example in all its dice-rolling glory.[1] (Hands rotated for convenience.)

	North ♠KQT3 ♥AT872 ♦— ♣AJT2	
West ♠A95 ♥QJ6543 ♦J ♣Q94		East ♠8742 ♥K9 ♦8543 ♣K73
	South ♠J6 ♥— ♦AKQT9762 ♣865	

South dealt and opened 3NT, which was passed out. Sitting West was Philip Alder, expert player and former bridge columnist for The New York Times. A heart lead would have set the contract by two, but Alder led the ♠A to take a proverbial look at dummy. This immediately set up declarer's spades for overtricks! Fun times.

Responses

Partner will normally pass an opening 3NT. However, he is allowed to bid if it's deemed necessary. There are several flavors of response schemes to choose from. Below is a summary of some common approaches.

Responder's Bid	Meaning
4♣	There are a couple ways to play this: 1. A weak bail-out bid, asking partner to pass or correct to 4♦. 2. Artificial, strong and forcing. Shows interest in slam. Asks opener to clarify her hand.
4♦	Again, a couple ways to play this: 1. Gerber, asking for aces. Responder should have a clear vision of what the final contract might be. 2. Artificial, strong and forcing (if 4♣ is weak).
4♥	Natural, showing a good 6+ card heart suit.
4♠	Natural, showing a good 6+ card spade suit.
4NT	Quantitative, inviting 6NT.
5♣	Bail-out bid, showing major-suit weakness but good support for both minors. Asks opener to pass or correct to 5♦.

Opener's Rebids After a Strong 4♣

There are multiple ways to define opener's rebids in response to a strong 4♣ ask.

Approach #1

Rebid	Meaning
4♦	Gerber.
4♥/♠	Cue bid showing a side-suit ace.
4NT	Minimum strength.

The same rules can apply over a strong 4♦ response, except that opener cannot use Gerber.

Approach #2

Alternatively, opener's rebids may describe suit length.

Rebid	Meaning
4♦/♥/♠	A singleton in the bid suit.
4NT	A semi-balanced hand, i.e. 2-2-2-7 or 2-2-7-2.
5♣/♦	Natural, to play.

In Competition

- If the opponents double 3NT for penalty (how unsporting!), responder may bid 4♣ as a runout bid, asking opener to pass or correct to 4♦.
- If the opponents overcall, a 4NT bid by responder is natural. It is neither quantitative nor Blackwood.

Defense to the Gambling 3NT

Expert Ron Klinger suggests the following approach to dealing with an opposing 3NT opening.[2]

Call	Meaning
Double	Penalty-oriented.
4♣	Takeout for the majors, with a preference for hearts.
4♦	Takeout for the majors, with a preference for spades.
4♥	Natural.
4♠	Natural.

References

[1] ACBL. Daily Bulletin, Volume 61, Number 9. 2019.

[2] Klinger, Ron. Bridge Conventions, Defences and Countermeasures. London, Weindenfeld & Nicolson, 2017.

See also

- Kabel 3NT
  A strong, artificial 3NT opening bid that asks partner for specific aces.
- Marvin 2♠
  An artificial 2♠ that shows a decent 7-card minor with a side control.
- Weak Two Bids
  Opening bids of 2♦/♥/♠ to show a 6-card suit with a weak hand.